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Let me be at my funniest: Instagram users' motivations for using Finsta (a.k.a., fake Instagram)

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ABSTRACT

Instagram users can create two types of account to manage their self-presentation strategically. On a real Instagram account (known as Rinsta), users highlight flattering aspects of self, whereas on a fake Instagram account (known as Finsta), users show unflattering aspects of self. We conducted an online survey with college Instagram users who used both Rinsta and Finsta (N = 149) to empirically uncover how user motivations and self-presentation behaviors were different between these two accounts. We found that Instagram users rated five user motivations (i.e., social interaction, self-expression, escapism, peeking, and archiving) higher for the Rinsta than for the Finsta, and they mainly created the Finsta to provide fun daily update and to socially bond with close friends. In addition, we observed that Instagram users presented their actual-self, ideal-self, deceptive-self, and impressive-self to a greater degree on the Rinsta than on the Finsta. Implications, limitations, and future directions are discussed.

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Fake Instagram; Real Instagram; User motivations; Self-presentation; Social media; Identity; Impression management; Context collapse

1. Introduction

Instagram is a popular social media platform that has more than 1 billion monthly users (Statista, 2018), and it empowers users to communicate with others via attractive visual cues. Just like other social network sites (SNS), Instagram is filled with users' positive self-presentation, mainly in the form of selfies (Hu, Manikonda, & Kambhampati, 2014). Instagram users present themselves in a positive light to their imagined audience, be it pretty-self (Tiggemann and Zaccardo, 2016), happy-self (Pounders, Kowalczyk, & Stowers, 2016), or positive-self (Waterloo, Baumgartner, Peter, & Valkenburg, 2018). This positive self-presentation satisfies both users and their audience (Manago, Graham, Greenfield, & Salimkhan, 2008), such that the former receives positive attention from the audience (Dumas, Maxwell-Wmith, Davis, & Giulietti, 2017) and the latter read about posts that verify their sociocultural values, beliefs, and standards (Chua & Chang, 2016).

Do Instagram users only present themselves in a positive light? The answer is 'No.' Anecdotal evidence tells us that Instagram users create two types of account to present themselves in both flattering and unflattering manner. A real Instagram account (known as Rinsta) is Instagram users' normal and primary account where users show they are leading a good, perfect life (e.g., photos of vacation, career accomplishments). On the contrary, a fake Instagram account (known as Finsta) is Instagram users' secondary and secret accounts where users show their unattractive, humiliating, and embarrassing sides, ranging from facial imperfections, depression and struggles, partying habit to love poems (Molina, 2017; Patterson, 2016; Safronova, 2015). With the term Finsta included in the Urban Dictionary as of 2015 (Finsta, 2015), the Finsta has gained its popularity over the years. On the Finsta, Instagram users do not worry about coming up with a clever caption or using filters to create a perfect photo. In addition, the Rinsta and Finsta are different from each other on the nature of the audience members. Instagram users add strangers,

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acquaintances, and friends on the Rinsta, whereas they only add real-world, intimate friends on the Finsta (Molina, 2017; Patterson, 2016; Safronova, 2015).

Based on these descriptions, it seems that Instagram users create Finsta for self-expression motivation (i.e., a desire to tell others about the self) (Lee, Lee, Moon, & Sung, 2015). Instagram users are highly restricted in their ability to express themselves to the fullest on their Rinsta because one form of self-presentation, including positive self, can mean different things for their diverse, distinct social groups who have been brought together as a homogenous unity, a phenomenon known as context collapse (boyd, 2008). To avoid offending someone from their friend list, Instagram users present a conservative and staid persona (known as vanilla self) that can be accepted by their social groups (Chua & Chang, 2016; Pitcan, Marwick, & boyd, 2018). However, individuals can have multiple selves that are governed by social contexts, including ideal-self (i.e., the self that one ideally would like to be), deceptive-self (i.e., the self that one actually is not), impressive-self (i.e., the self that one wishes to impress), actual-self (i.e., the self that one actually is), and exploration-self (i.e., the self that one is exploring) (McConnell, 2011; Michikyan, Dennis, & Subrahmanyam, 2015). But with the Rinsta, Instagram users are restricted to presenting a singular identity, while the Finsta may be an outlet to engage in diverse self-expression.

Beyond self-expression, how might Rinsta and Finsta differ on other user motivations? Research indicates that Instagram users employ the Rinsta for various reasons, including self-expression, social interaction, and escapism (Lee et al., 2015; Sheldon & Bryant, 2016). Rinsta and Finsta are different in the nature of the audience members and contents, which are important factors influencing SNS users' online identity performance (Vitak, 2012), and we hypothesized that Instagram users would rate the Rinsta and Finsta differently on other user motivations. We also examined how Instagram users' self-presentation behaviors were different between the Rinsta and Finsta (Michikyan, Dennis, & Subrahmanyam, 2015). If the Finsta can grant Instagram users to engage in unrestricted self-expression, as hypothesized, this freedom may allow users to present different types of self at different levels on the Rinsta and Finsta.

In sum, by examining how user motivations and self-presentation behaviors were different between the Rinsta and Finsta, we sought out to advance our understanding on the use of multiple accounts by SNS users to manage their multiple identities online.

2. Literature review

2.1. *Positive self-presentation*

Classic theories on self inform us that we have multiple, possible selves that expand across time (past, present, future), take on different valence (e.g., positive, negative), and occupy diverse roles, characteristics, and traits (James, 1910; Cooley, 1902; Markus & Nurius, 1986). Our possible selves are "limited only by their imagination" (p. 213, Markus & Ruvolo, 1989), and each possible self uniquely represents our hope, aspirations, goals, and fears (Markus & Nurius, 1986). Among all possible selves, we are highly motivated to present our best self (i.e., one's identity that consists of positive, socially desirable attributes) to other individuals (Goffman, 1959). According to self-presentation theory (Goffman, 1959), individuals strategically present their best self by allowing audience to see their behaviors on a front stage, with their impression management activities labelled as a performance. On the front stage, individuals express identity cues, which can be attributes about themselves (e.g., appearance, language, manner) or physical environment (e.g., furniture, decoration), to deliver the desired impression to audience. Expression of one's identity cues can be given or given off. Yet, expressions that are given are deliberately staged by individuals while expressions that are given off cannot be staged and manipulated by individuals. This gives audience the opportunity to look for match between the cues given and the cues given off to infer the validity of individuals' conveyed impression. After the performance, individuals retrieve to a backstage where they "can drop his front, forgot speaking in his lines and step out of character" (Goffman, 1959, p. 488). On this backstage, individuals reveal their true tendency, which may contradict their front stage behaviors and brush up on a next identity performance for the same or different audience (Goffman, 1959).

Applying Goffman's (1959) dramaturgical terms to Instagram, Instagram users' profile page can be considered as the front stage as this space showcases the identity cues that are relevant in fostering the desired self-image (e.g., selfies in an expensive restaurant) (Hogan, 2010; Zhao, Grasmuck, & Martin, 2008). Consistent with this view, research indicates Instagram users construct overly positive self-images on their Instagram. For instance, Chua and Chang (2016) found that female Instagram users edited their photos to correct for their facial and bodily imperfections, so they can meet their peers' beauty standard. Similarly, Smith and Sanderson (2015) observed that athletes strategically built positive self-images, such as "humanitarian," "family-driven," or "dedicated athlete," to enhance their public popularity. Instagram users can also engage in deceptive self-presentation strategies by exaggerating physical and personality attributes (Guadagno, Okdie, & Kruse, 2012) or manipulating user engagement metrics (e.g., purchasing Likes and followers) (Dumas et al., 2017).

Taken further, positive self-presentation is essential for SNS users to obtain social and material outcomes. For instance, Ting (2014) found that Instagram users presented themselves as a likable, helpless, and competent person to receive support and empathy or attract a potential romantic partner. Similarly, Pitcan et al. (2018) observed that SNS users presented themselves in a respectable and professional manner to enhance their chances of professional success. In addition, by looking at their idealized and socially desirable public persona, SNS users are affirmed that they are a good person overall (Toma & Hancock, 2013), and they can enhance their self-esteem (Leary & Kowalski, 1990).

As for Instagram users' backstage, it would be any effort exerted by the users in crafting the contents for their front page, such as their time spent in editing for photos, writing about a clever post caption, and arranging personal data (Ellison et al., 2007; Krämer & Winter, 2008). As put forth by the self-presentation theory (Goffman, 1959), some of the identity cues are given off by individuals. On SNS, these given off cues are typically other-generated (i.e., information about a user made available by their friends) and system-generated cues (i.e., information about a user made available by the social media system; Tong, Van Der Heide, Langwell, & Walther, 2008). While it is hard to control for the system-generated cues, some of the strategies that Instagram users use to control for the other-generated cues are untagging themselves from the contents presenting them in a negative light and unfriending their friends who made such unflattering contents (Lang & Barton, 2014).

In sum, SNS users can take advantage of technological affordances of new media technologies, such as customization and asynchronicity, to strategically balance their front stage and backstage behaviors to impress the audience, and this carefully curated self on the front stage may not perfectly represent reality (Toma & Carlson, 2015). Yet, in light of the increasing popularity of the Finsta, would similar self-presentation hold constant across the Rinsta and Finsta? In the next section, we discuss motivations for employing the Finsta, and how the Rinsta and Finsta might induce distinct self-presentation behaviors.

2.2. *Motivations for fake Instagram*

Self-expression is one's motivation to tell others about themselves (Lee et al., 2015), including one's negative and positive thoughts and feelings (Harter, 2002; Reinecke and Trepte, 2014). On the Rinsta, Instagram users cannot fully express themselves truthfully because they need to be mindful about their diverse, distinct social groups who hold different expectations, beliefs and standards for the users (Marwick & boyd, 2010). Hence, on this account, Instagram users' self-expression is confined to a vanilla self that would be normatively acceptable to all audiences (Pitcan et al., 2018). For instance, Wang et al. (2011) found that Facebook users regretted making posts mentioning their use of illegal drugs or about the time they skipped school. While these behaviors came across as cool and unique to their friends, they elicited disapproval from their family, school teachers, and potential employers. Presentation of a singular identity, regardless of its positivity, demands SNS users to constantly exercise self-censorship, which can be cognitively exhausting and undermine users' wellbeing (Krause, 2007).

Given this, Instagram users' creation of the Finsta may reflect their desire to express the type of self that is not governed by audience members. It is not uncommon for SNS users to employ multiple social media accounts to express multiple identities (Vitak, Blasiola, Patil, & Litt, 2015). Research indicates that the unique features of social media influence the type of self that SNS users present on each platform. For instance, individuals present their professional self on Twitter and LinkedIn, because the culture of these platforms emphasize on information sharing with loose, professional connections and de-emphasize on reciprocal interactions with "followers" (Kwak, Lee, Park, & Moon, 2010). Snapchat offers users with diverse toolkits to strengthen the closeness and intimacy between the users and their close friends (e.g., diverse mode of communication modalities, self-destructive content feature after 24-hours), and these features allow users to present their actual-self (Choi & Sung, 2018). Facebook brings together large, diverse social groups whom users know from both offline and online, encouraging users to present their socially and interesting self on Facebook (Zhao et al., 2008). For Instagram specifically, it is well known for its superior visual sharing capability and archives users' contents on their profile page, and as such, Instagram users tend to portray creative and ideal-self on this particular platform (Sheldon & Bryant, 2016).

The Finsta may be an account where Instagram users express an unedited and socially undesirable identity (Stutzman & Hartzog, 2012). Instead of creating the Finsta, Instagram users can also manage their multiple identities by sending a direct message to their close friends for a private self-disclosure. However, Instagram users may still prefer using the Finsta as they do not see the activities of the rest of their other friends on their feed, thereby completely removing their impression management concerns. We hypothesized that Instagram users would rate self-expression higher on the Finsta than on the Rinsta:

H1. Instagram users will rate self-expression motivation higher on the Finsta than on the Rinsta.

Beyond self-expression motivation, how might Instagram users rate the Rinsta and Finsta on other user motivations? Studies indicate that other motivations exist for using Instagram. For instance, Lee et al., (2015) identified five Instagram user motivations, which are social interaction, archiving, self-expression, escapism, and peeking. Similarly, Sheldon and Bryant (2016) reported surveillance, documentation, coolness, and creativity as four Instagram user motivations. With the absence of context collapse and impression management concern on the Finsta, we speculate that Instagram users would rate the Rinsta and Finsta differently on other user motivations (Molina, 2017; Patterson, 2016; Safronova, 2015). In the current study, we followed the 5 user motivations that have been identified by Lee et al., (2015) to capture greater user motivations. We posed our first research question as the follow:

Research question 1 (RQ1): Do Instagram users rate the Rinsta and Finsta differently on social interaction, archiving, escapism, and peeking motivation?

It is also important to explore how user motivations, especially self-expression, might translate into different self-presentation behaviors across the Rinsta and Finsta. As previously mentioned, we have multiple selves (Markus & Ruvolo, 1989), and it may be that the absence of context collapse and impression management concerns influence the types of self that Instagram users project onto the Rinsta and Finsta. In this study, we examined five types of self (i.e., actual-self, ideal-self, deceptive-self, impression-self, and exploration-self) as these self-presentation behaviors have been observed in other social media platforms (Michikyan et al., 2015). We posed our second research question as the follow:

Research question 2 (RQ2): Do Instagram users present actual-self, ideal-self, deceptive-self, impression-self and exploration-self to a different degree on the Rinsta and Finsta?

3. Methods

3.1. *Participants*

One-hundred and forty-nine undergraduate students (N = 149) who employed both Rinsta and Finsta were recruited from a large U.S. university for extra-course credit. Participants' age was ranged from 18 to 25-years old (M_{age} = 20.01, SD_{age} = 1.16; Female = 133), with 88.9% identified as Caucasians, 7.4% as Asian/Pacific Islander, 6.7% % as Hispanic/Latino, 1.3% as African American, and 0.7% as Other. Among all participants, six participants did not report their age, and three participants did not report their gender and ethnicity.

3.2. *Procedure*

After acquiring course instructors' approval, the study's online survey link was posted on the course websites to recruit participants who had both Rinsta and Finsta. Once interested participants had clicked onto the study link, they were directed to the study survey site administered on Qualtrics and read an informed consent that outlined the study purpose, as well as the definition of the Rinsta and Finsta (i.e., "A real Instagram, known as Rinsta, is your *primary and normal* Instagram account where you share general posts with a large social network. A fake Instagram, known as Finsta, is your *secondary and secrete* Instagram account where you share posts with a small social network"). Afterwards, participants who agreed to take part in the study proceeded to a next page.

There were three sections within the study survey. Throughout the survey, participants were informed that the survey will use the terms Rinsta and Finsta to refer to their real and fake Instagram accounts. In the first section, participants provided basic account information about their Rinsta and Finsta, such as the number of "followers" and "following." In the second section, participants first answered to a self-presentation behavior measure for the Rinsta and Finsta, followed by a user motivation measure for the Rinsta and Finsta. In measuring user motivations and self-presentation behaviors, items on the Rinsta and Finsta were arranged in a separate block and the presentation order of blocks was randomized, so that some participants saw items for the Finsta first before items for the Rinsta while other participants saw items for the Rinsta first before items for the Finsta. This randomization of presentation order of blocks was only executed for the second part of the survey to control for potential question order effects. Lastly, in the third section, participants answered to the two open-ended questions that addressed their perception of the Rinsta and Finsta and their motivation for using the Finsta. After responding to open-ended questions, participants were thanked for their time.

3.3. *Measurements*

Unless otherwise specified, all established measures employed a 7-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly disagree to 7 = Strongly agree).

3.3.1. *User motivations*

Participants indicated their motivation for using the Rinsta and Finsta with a scale developed by Lee et al. (2015). The scale assessed 5 user motivations, which were self-expression (5-items), social interaction (8-items), escapism (5-items), peeking (4-items) and archiving (5-items). One item for archiving (i.e., "To record my traces (e.g., trip) via photomap") was not used for the study, as Instagram recently deleted this photomap feature. See Table 1 for reliabilities and sample items for all study measures.

3.3.2. *Self-presentation behaviors*

Participants indicated to what extent they expressed 5 types of self on the Rinsta and Finsta, which were actual-self (5-items), ideal-self (2-items), deceptive-self (4-items), exploration-self (3-items) and

Table 1. A list of study measures: user motivations and self-presentation behaviors.

Motivation	Sample items
	"Please indicate your agreement with the following statements." "I use Finsta/Rinsta …"
Self-expression (5-items)	
Rinsta: Cronbach's α = 0.78	"To provide my update," "To share my personal information with others."
Finsta: Cronbach's α = 0.81	
Social interaction (8-items)	
Rinsta: Cronbach's α = 0.83	"To interact with a number of people," "To communicate with friends and
Finsta: Cronbach's α = 0.84	family."
Escapism (5-items)	
Rinsta: Cronbach's α = 0.85	"To escape from reality," "To avoid loneliness."
Finsta: Cronbach's α = 0.84	
Peeking (4-items)	
Rinsta: Cronbach's α = 0.85	"To browse photos related to my interests," "To browse a variety of fancy
Finsta: Cronbach's α = 0.91	photos."
Archiving (5-items)	
Rinsta: Cronbach's α = 0.72	To record daily events through photos," "To create my personal space."
Finsta: Cronbach's α = 0.69	
Self-presentation	
Actual-self (5-items)	"Please indicate your agreement with the following statements."
Rinsta: Cronbach's α = 0.89	"Who I am on (Rinsta)(Finsta)is similar to who I am offline," "The way I present
Finsta: Cronbach's α = 0.88	myself on (Rinsta)(Finsta) is how I am in real life."
Ideal-self (2-items)	"I post things on my (Rinsta)(Finsta)to show aspects of who I want to be," "Who
Rinsta: Spearman-Brown coefficient = 0.77	I want to be is often reflected in the things I do on my (Rinsta)(Finsta)."
Finsta: Spearman-Brown coefficient = 0.83	
Deceptive-self (4-items)	"I sometimes try to be someone other than my actual-self on (Rinsta)(Finsta)," "I
Rinsta: Cronbach's α = 0.77	post information about myself on my (Rinsta)(Finsta) that is not true."
Finsta: Cronbach's α = 0.87	
Exploration-self (3-items)	"I feel like I have many sides to myself and I show it on my (Rinsta)(Finsta)," "I
Rinsta: Cronbach's α = 0.71	change my photos on (Rinsta)(Finsta) to show people the different aspects of
Finsta: Cronbach's α = 0.70	who I am."
Impressive-self (3-items)	"I try to impress others with the photos I post of myself on (Rinsta)(Finsta)," "I
Rinsta: Cronbach's α = 0.73	only show the aspects of myself on (Rinsta)(Finsta)that I know people would
Finsta: Cronbach's α = 0.71	like."

Note. For each subscale, its reliability was calculated based on a total number of items.

impressive-self (3-items) (Michikyan, Subrahmanyam, & Dennis, 2014). The ideal-self subscale consisted of 2-items, and we computed Spearman-Brown coefficient to assess its internal reliability as this indicator has been shown to be more effective for 2-item measure than Cronbach's alpha (Eisinga, Te Grotenhuis, & Pelzer, 2013).

3.3.3. *Open-ended questions*

We asked participants two open-ended questions. The first question asked about how they differentiated the Rinsta and Finsta in general sense, "How is a Finsta different from a Rinsta?" and the second question asked about their motivations for using the Finsta, "What is your reason for using a Finsta?" This second question addressed our RQ1.

3.4. *Basic account information*

Participants provided basic account information for their Rinsta and Finsta. For each account, we asked the following five questions: (1) "Who do you add on this account?" (2) "How long did you have this account?" (3) "What is a number of followings?" (4) "What is a number of followers?" and (5) "What is the privacy setting for this account?"

4. Results

4.1. Descriptive information of Instagram accounts

For the Rinsta, participants reported they added a diverse group of audience, which included their immediate friends, family, acquaintances, celebrities, mutual friends, work colleagues, and employers, and they had their Rinsta for 6 years on average. A majority of the Rinsta were set as private (n = 109). On average, these Rinsta accounts had 1074.11 "followers" and 785.50 "following." For the Finsta, participants added only close friends whom they knew in real life. Of all participants, other than close friends, only one participant mentioned they added their family members, and two participants mentioned that they followed celebrities. All participants' Finsta was set on private. Few participants mentioned that their Instagram ID was not associated with their real name on the Finsta, so other users would not be able to find their Finsta account. On average, participants had 60.71 "followers" and 63.45 "following."

4.2. Preliminary analysis on study measures

We conducted confirmatory factor analyses to ensure that user motivation and self-presentation behavior measures for the Rinsta and Finsta confirmed to the factor structure identified by past researchers (Lee et al., 2015; Michikyan, Subrahmanyam, & Dennis, 2014). For user motivation measure, the measurement fits were both reasonably acceptable using the guideline proposed by Hu and Bentler (1999) and Holbert and Stephenson (2002) (Finsta: χ^2 (176) = 308.994, p < .001, TLI = .90, RMSEA = .071 with 90% confidence interval of .058 to .084, CFI = .92, and SRMR = .066; Rinsta: χ^2 (176) = 356.085, p < .001, TLI = .87, RMSEA = .083 with 90% confidence interval of .071 to .096, CFI = .89, and SRMR = .08).[1] For self-presentation behavior measure, we modeled five latent factors (actual-self, deceptive-self, ideal-self, impressive-self, and exploration-self) and the measurement fits were acceptable (Finsta: χ^2 (91) = 178.305, p < .001, TLI = .89, RMSEA = .08 with 90% confidence interval of .063–.098, CFI = .91, and SRMR = .08; Rinsta: χ^2 (91) = 184.497, p < .001, TLI =.88, RMSEA = .08 with 90% confidence interval of .06–.11, CFI = .91, and SRMR = .089). These results indicate that user motivation and self-presentation behavior measures for Rinsta and Finsta confirmed to the factor structure identified by past researchers (Lee et al., 2015; Michikyan et al., 2015).

4.3. Analysis on user motivation and self-presentation measures

To address our H1, RQ1, and RQ2, we conducted a series of paired-samples t-tests on user motivation and self-presentation behavior measures. We found that participants rated self-expression (M = 4.79, SE = .11), social interaction (M = 5.24, SE = .09), escapism (M = 3.85, SE = .10), peeking (M = 5.54, SE = .10) and archiving (M = 4.75, SE = .11) significantly higher for the Rinsta than for the Finsta (self-expression: M = 3.89, SE = .12; social interaction: M = 2.93, SE = .11; escapism: M = 3.12, SE = .13; peeking: M = 2.24, SE = .13; archiving: M = 3.86, SE = .14). These results disconfirm our H1 and at the same time, partially provide answer to our RQ1.

As for self-presentation, participants rated actual-self (M = 5.24, SE = .10), ideal-self (M = 5.02, SE = .11), deceptive-self (M = 2.65, SE = .12), and impressive-self (M = 5.08, SE = .12) significantly higher for the Rinsta than for the Finsta (actual-self: M = 4.76, SE = .12; ideal-self: M = 3.06, SE = .14; deceptive-self: M = 2.39, SE = .12; impressive-self: M = 2.51, SE = .12), but they did not differentiate two accounts on exploration-self (Rinsta: M = 4.23, SE = .12; Finsta: M = 4.05, SE = .13). These results provide answer to our RQ2. See Table 2 for a result summary.

[1]Four items ("To keep in touch with friends far away" and "Because people around me use Instagram" for social interaction; "To take fancy photos and save them online" and "To update photos and videos with various filters applied" for archiving) were deleted for Finsta and Rinsta user motivation scales due to their low factor loadings to the latent factors (r's < .50).

Table 2. Paired-samples t-test results on user motivation and self-presentation behaviors.

	Mean (SE)		
	Rinsta	Finsta	t-statistics
User motivations			
Self-expression	4.79 (.11)	3.89 (.12)	t (143) = −6.52, p < .001, r^2= .23
Social interaction	5.24 (.09)	2.93 (.11)	t (143) = −17.03, p < .001, r^2 = .67
Escapism	3.85 (.10)	3.12 (.13)	t (145) = −6.85, p < .001, r^2 = .19
Peeking	5.54 (.10)	2.24 (.13)	t (143) = −19.93, p < .001, r^2 = .74
Archiving	4.75 (.11)	3.86 (.14)	t (143) = −5.66, p < .001, r^2 = .18
Self-presentation			
Actual-self	5.24 (.10)	4.76 (.12)	t (143) = −3.64, p < .001, r^2 = .08
Ideal-self	5.02 (.11)	3.06 (.14)	t (143) = −13.39, p < .001, r^2 = .56
Deceptive-self	2.65 (.12)	2.39 (.12)	t (144) = −2.15, p < .05, r^2 = .03
Exploration-self	4.23 (.12)	4.05 (.13)	t (143) = −1.30, p = .20, r^2 = .01
Impressive-self	5.08 (.12)	2.51 (.12)	t (143) = −18.34, p < .001, r^2 = .70

Note. Two-tailed significance is presented.

4.4. *Analysis on open-ended question to user motivation*

We adopted an open coding and constant comparison method to meaningfully interpret participants' responses to our two open-ended questions. Each author independently coded for participants' responses and then compared the results. Iterated discussions were held until the authors fully agreed upon the main themes and subthemes (Strauss & Corbin, 1997).

We found three dominant themes to the first question "What is your reason for using a Finsta?" – sharing funny posts, expressing the self, and following friends.

Sharing funny posts. Most participants (n = 61) indicated they used the Finsta to provide fun updates of their everyday. While the Rinsta was strictly reserved to provide cool updates of their life, the Finsta enabled participants to provide a fuller daily update, encompassing both the cool and uncool moments. For instance,

> *"I created Finsta because I had a lot of funny content that I rarely got to share with people because I don't feel comfortable posting it on a public platform."*

> *"My life is so crazy and many funny and crazy things happen to me. I felt like sharing them."*

> *"My friends often tell me that I am very funny, so I created one to keep my friends updated on my life in a funny way."*

In addition, some participants (n = 37) saw the Finsta as a social bonding tool in which they made funny posts to make their close friends laugh. The Finsta was a place to archive their crazy behaviors and a place to share their inside jokes. For instance,

> *"To create a more intimate social media page that is funny and allowed me to connect with friends on a real level."*

> *"So I could use it as an outlet to post funny and embarrassing pictures to make me and my friends laugh."*

> *"My friends and I will post more pics of one another than anything. Generally unflattering pictures that we wouldn't want others seeing. We just make fun of each other or post funny stories from the week."*

Expressing the self: For a few participants (n = 25), the Finsta allowed for a better self-expression, and this self-expression was not necessarily limited to expressing their funny and goofy side, but also expressing their craziness, negativity, and more. These participants saw the Finsta as a medium to express their true and honest feelings. For instance,

> *"To share my inner crazy personality to only my close friends; my Finsta is totally care free."*

> *"To rebel against the harsh standards of Rinsta and express my true feelings."*

> "*To be funny, to have a place to vent about my feelings.*"

Furthermore, this ability to be their true self on the Finsta allowed them to engage in Instagram activities that they felt uncomfortable to do on the Rinsta, such as following certain celebrities and clothing brands.

Following friends: Some participants (n = 21) indicated they used the Finsta because their friends had one, and hence, they were a passive observer. For instance,

> *"It is a trending form of social media. Most of my friends have one. We used to have one for all of my roommates and we all had access to it."*

> *"I was convinced by my best friend, just to mess around and really to just follow her Finsta"*

We found three dominant themes to the second question "How is a Finsta different from a Rinsta?" – lack of impression management, better self-expression, and others.

Lack of impression management: Most participants expressed (n = 97) that they did not care about managing their impression on the Finsta as they did on the Rinsta. That is, on the Finsta, their posts were completely unfiltered and unedited and hence, these posts were often inappropriate (e.g., drinking, partying). For instance,

> *"Finsta, I do not care about what I look like. I post embarrassing pictures of myself and stories of my days/nights before. I try to be mostly funny and treat it kinda like a mini vent session. Rinsta is all looks."*

> *"I don't filter what I post on Finsta and don't care how much engagement (likes or comments) I earn. For Rinsta, I am super picky about which photo to use, how I edit the picture, and what time I post the picture. For my Finsta, I just select a random video or picture of myself doing something funny or embarrassing and post it instantly without much thought going into it."*

> *"On Finsta, I post things that I might not want strangers or potential employers to see. This often includes images of my drinking or looking intoxicated. I also post longer captions on Finsta, often describing how I am feeling. Only my close friends follow me on Finsta so I can post anything I want, whereas family members follow my Rinsta and I try to keep that 'clean'."*

Interestingly, this unfiltering behavior extended over to their posts' caption length and the posting frequency. On the Finsta, participants wrote longer captions and posted contents multiple times a day in comparison to the Rinsta, as they did not care for receiving "Likes" and "Comments."

Better self-expression: Echoing what we have found earlier, some participants (n = 32) indicated that they can be their true self on the Finsta where they shared their personal secrets, as well as different sides of themselves. For instance,

> *"My Finsta expresses a more vulnerable side of me that I am only comfortable showing my close friends, because they already know that side of me. Once you get to know me, I can be quite the excitement and can be loud and wild. Most people who follow my Rinsta don't see that side of me because they aren't someone my closest friends."*

> *"Finsta is a place for pretty much anything- pictures where I may not look great, embarrassing photos (within reason) of myself or friends; a place where I can just express myself within a smaller group of people."*

Others: Twelve participants (n = 12) mentioned Rinsta and Finsta differed based on the posting frequency and privacy setting of the account, with lower posting frequency and private account setting for the Finsta compared to the Rinsta.

5. Findings and discussion

5.1. *Decomposing user motivations for Finsta and Rinsta*

In this study, we uncovered how Instagram users' motivation and self-presentation behaviors were different between the Rinsta and Finsta. As for user motivations, many of the participants indicated in their open-ended response that they used the Finsta to provide fun daily updates, including their humiliating and crazy moments, without fearing about making "wrong" impression or offending someone from their friend list. Moreover, this sharing behavior seemed deeply social in nature: some

of these participants shared funny posts on the Finsta just to make their close friends laugh. On the Rinsta, it is hard for Instagram users to establish intimate and close bonding with their close friends as they typically post cool and conservative pictures meant to satisfy their large and public audiences. However, the Finsta, which was devoid of context collapse and impression management concerns, allowed Instagram users to use satire, inside jokes and humor to enhance social intimacy with close friends. For some users, the Finsta allowed them to show their negativity and vulnerability. Few users employed the Finsta just to follow their close friends' account, and this act of following may reflect either one form of social support (e.g., "Let me follow you, so you have an audience"), as well as a mindlessness bandwagon (i.e., "If everyone is creating one, I should be too") (Sundar, 2008).

Interestingly, we found that Instagram users rated self-expression, social interaction, escapism, archiving, and peeking higher on the Rinsta than on the Finsta. These findings make sense for some motivations, specifically, social interaction and peeking. For social interaction, the Rinsta has a high number of audience (Lee et al., 2015), and as such, it offers users with greater opportunity to interact with diverse groups, as well as to browse through more interesting and diverse photos than the Finsta (i.e., peeking). It is surprising that the Rinsta was rated higher for self-expression, escapism, and archiving than the Finsta. Based on our qualitative findings, although self-expression was not the major reason for employing the Finsta (indicated by 25 out of 144 participants), one would think that the absence of context collapse and impression management concerns would make the Finsta more ideal place to present the truthful and unconstrained aspects of themselves than the Rinsta. However, this was not the case. One explanation for these seemingly contradictory results is that users may feel pressured to only present their funny self on the Finsta. As the Finsta is an acknowledged and designated space to be silly, there may be a benign social pressure for users to only be funny, making users perceive the Finsta as a venue to present non-funny-self. In fact, this explanation is consistent with what we found in the thematic analysis. As participants employed the Finsta for social purpose (i.e., to make their friends laugh and provide fun daily updates), they may go an extra mile to be funnier than they actually are or they want to be (Duffy, 2017).

One would also expect Instagram users to rate escapism and archiving higher on the Finsta than on the Rinsta, as there are more pictures being updated from other users to distract their attention and users can post pictures anytime. It may be that Finsta was just "too real." As users and their friends posted pictures that closely reflect the reality, the Finsta may constantly remind users of their actual reality, rather than allowing them to immerse themselves in an illusion that "life is perfect." On the Rinsta, perhaps users can maintain such illusion due to the positive self-presentation posts made by their large, social network. For archiving, perhaps Instagram users' desire to leave "perfect" pictures to track and reflect their life made the Rinsta more desirable than the Finsta.

5.2. *Decomposing self-presentation behaviors on Finsta and Rinsta*

As for self-presentation behaviors, we found that Instagram users presented their actual-self, deceptive-self, ideal-self, and impressive-self to a greater degree on the Rinsta than on the Finsta. As for actual-self, as discussed above, the Finsta may benignly force participants to express themselves funnier than they actually are, and it also may be that participants were not used to expressing this type of self on Instagram, evoking a perception that this type of self is not their actual-self. Participants also rated deceptive-self higher on the Rinsta than on the Finsta, although the means for both accounts were below 3 (see Table 2). This finding makes sense, as Instagram users exaggerate the positive aspects of themselves on the Rinsta to please audience, and they may feel as if they are presenting a false-self. On the Finsta, however, the users can present themselves in a realistic and honest manner as there is a lack of impression concerns. For exploration-self, as the Rinsta is used to explore more diverse selves, including one's ideal-self and impressive-self, compared to the Finsta, users may feel like they are being more explorative on the former than the latter. Finsta may benignly force the participants to express only the funny aspect of the self and as such, they may not perceive the account as a place to express other multiple selves, such as ideal-self and impressive-self.

Our results suggest that the Rinsta and Finsta exert two different types of impression management pressure on Instagram users, albeit different in intensity. The formal pressures the users to look good, whereas the latter pressures the users to be funny. This insight raises an interesting question of why Instagram users would be motivated to use two accounts against the pressure. It may be that one's need for social validation and belonging are such powerful fundamental human needs that drive SNS users to actively seek out venues to express their multiple identities, with each identity fulfilling different needs (i.e., a positive self on the Rinsta fulfilling social validation needs, and a funny-self on the Finsta fulfilling belonging needs).

5.3. *Study implications*

Theoretically, we extend the self-presentation theory (Goffman, 1959) by demonstrating that individuals are tactful in expressing their multiple identities. As some identities are socially undesirable, individuals selectively select an appropriate to present those identities. For Instagram users, the Finsta is a venue to express funny, goofy and vulnerable self. While Goffman (1959) conceptualized a performer's backstage as the space where only the performer and his team members can enter, our study suggests that the performer (i.e., Finsta users) allow other performers to enter their backstage if they are close and trustworthy. In this sense, the Finsta is another performance stage where users perform their funny self, and it cannot be considered as the true backstage where the performer can relax and step out from the character.

In addition, our results provide consistent evidence that active SNS use (vs. passive use) is associated with positive user outcomes, such as feeling of social support (Ellison, Steinfield, & Lampe, 2007) and inspiration (Meier and Schäfer, 2018). Active SNS users engage in direct interaction with a platform, while passive SNS users simply browse through a platform without any direct interaction (Ellison et al., 2007). Many of our participants actively participated on the Finsta by posting funny, mundane contents to derive social and personal satisfactions, and this suggests that the link between active SNS use and positive user outcomes can also be applied to the Finsta. We observed that there were few passive Finsta users who created the account just to follow their friends. Passive SNS use has been associated with negative outcomes, such as feeling of loneliness (Burke, Marlow, & Lento, 2010) and envy (Scherr, Toma, & Schuster, 2018), and it has been shown that depression positively predicts passive SNS use. Thus, we recommend social media designers to think about simple and convenient features (e.g., Like) that can allow passive users, especially those who are depressed, to derive meaningful social intimacy and satisfaction from using the Finsta.

6. Limitations and future work

Our study has several limitations. First, given the online nature of our study, we did not receive rich and elaborated answers to the two opened-ended questions. For instance, most of our participants used a simple term "funny" to describe the contents they posted on the Finsta. Some participants mentioned they posted socially inappropriate photos, such as drinking and partying, which raises possibility that some posts on the Finsta may even contain antisocial behaviors. In fact, news reports indicate that few college students were expelled from their universities for posting racial slurs on the Finsta, and their antisocial behaviors were exposed because their close friends shared those contents publicly via screenshot (Herron, 2018). There is great risk of their privacy and trust being violated on the Finsta, and future work can examine what makes Finsta users to erroneously believe their posts on the Finsta, which may be socially inappropriate, would not be leaked by their close friends, and researchers can conduct focus group and interview to receive elaborate user responses. Second, our participants mainly consisted of female college Instagram users, and other researchers should be cautious in making generalization to other populations. An interesting research question is first, whether the Finsta is only popular for female college users and second,

if so, what the underlying reason is. Research indicates that females place more effort to maintain social relationships than males (Maccoby, 1990), and this gender difference in interpersonal orientation may make the Finsta an appealing relationship maintenance tool only for female Instagram users. Relatedly, future work needs to uncover whether a Finsta usage is strictly a college student phenomenon and explore how adult population might cope with restricted self-expression on SNS.

Despite these limitations, our study raises important future research questions on the Finsta. For instance, does Snapchat serve the same function as the Finsta for users? Research indicates that Snapchat users send their close friends with every day "carefree" moments (e.g., selfie while sitting on a toilet) (Bayer, Ellison, Schoenebeck, & Falk, 2016; Piwek & Joinson, 2016). In this sense, both Finsta and Snapchat are used to check in with their close friends via strong visual cues and allow users to express the aspects of the self that are considered "too mundane" for Facebook or Rinsta. Relatedly, future research may look at how Finsta users' behaviors translate to other social media platforms. For instance, are Finsta users more likely to create another fake account on Facebook? If yes, do they create fake accounts on other SNS for different or same purpose (i.e., social intimacy)? These research questions will help social media designers build better interface features for each type of account on different SNS that can satisfy users' different needs, with implications to their wellbeing. Moreover, these questions will provide insight to social media researchers in understanding how the psychology of the Finsta users might be different from that of the Finsta non-users. Lastly, as our findings suggest, the current established typology of motivations for general Instagram use is less applicable to the Finsta, and researchers are highly encouraged to develop a new scale that can accurately capture Instagram users' motivation for using Finsta, with a specific focus to social bonding and self-expression.

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